

The Theological Center (Acts 15:1-35)

Rick Gamache · Cornerstone Community Church, Burnsville, MN · October 4, 2026

Acts 15:1-35

PRIMARY TEXT

46 min

SERMON LENGTH

35

SCRIPTURE
REFERENCES

29

SECTIONS WE MAPPED

THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

Salvation comes through faith in Jesus alone — nothing can be added to Christ's finished work on the cross, and any requirement beyond faith in him distorts the gospel and insults God.

Summary

Rick Gamache positions Acts 15 as the theological and structural center of Luke's narrative — the Jerusalem Council that definitively answered how a person is saved. When false teachers demanded that Gentile converts be circumcised and keep the Mosaic law in addition to faith in Christ, the apostles convened to defend the gospel itself. Peter, Paul, Barnabas, and James each testified that God makes no distinction between Jew and Gentile, cleansing hearts by faith alone. The council's decision — salvation by grace alone through faith alone in Christ alone — preserved the gospel for all future generations. Gamache shows how the theological danger was greater than any physical persecution: adding anything to Christ's finished work 'un-Christ's' him and insults the sufficiency of his sacrifice. The sermon culminates in celebration that Jesus is enough, with communion serving as the weekly reminder of the glorious exchange: his righteousness for our sin.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/CornerstoneBurnsville/sermons/the-theological-center-acts-15-1-35-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The sermon's central argument is that salvation comes through faith in Christ alone, with nothing added — defending justification by grace alone against works-righteousness.
- **Christology** — Gamache emphasizes that adding any requirement to Christ's work 'un-Christ's' him, demeans his perfect obedience, and insults the sufficiency of his sacrifice on the cross.
- **Ecclesiology** — The sermon traces how the Jerusalem Council established that the church is one people drawn from all nations, united by faith rather than ethnic identity or ritual observance.
- **Covenant Theology** — James's appeal to Amos shows that Gentile inclusion was not an afterthought but God's plan from the beginning, fulfilling prophetic promises about Messiah's worldwide people.

Themes

The sufficiency of Christ's finished work

Salvation by grace alone through faith alone

The danger of adding to the gospel

Unity in the multi-ethnic church

Theological precision as thrilling and perilous

Editor notes

- Gamache's use of Chesterton to frame theological precision as 'dangerous and exciting' rather than dull is rhetorically brilliant — it transforms what could be dry doctrinal debate into high-stakes drama.
- The pastoral aside creating empathy for the Judaizers (unit 8) is a strong interpretive move that prevents the congregation from smugly dismissing ancient error while simultaneously committing modern versions of it.
- The illustration of receiving a 'free' gift only to be handed a bill later (unit 11) makes the emotional devastation of the false teaching immediately visceral and contemporary.
- The sermon's structure moves seamlessly from exegesis to doxology, culminating in communion as participatory application — doctrine becoming worship without didacticism giving way to sentimentalism.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. When Orthodoxy Is the Most Dangerous Thing in the Room

Drawing on Chesterton, this article argues that theological precision isn't boring church business — it's thrilling and perilous because small errors in doctrine create massive blunders in human happiness. Acts 15 exemplifies how getting the gospel right or wrong determines eternal destinies.

FROM: UNITS 2-3, WHERE GAMACHE USES CHESTERTON TO REFRAME THEOLOGICAL DEBATE AS DANGEROUS AND EXCITING

2. False Doctrine Can Flourish Even When Apostles Are Still Alive

If the early church — with living apostles and eyewitnesses to the resurrection — could be infiltrated by false teaching within 18 years of Pentecost, how much more vigilant must we be? This article explores the sobering warning of Acts 15:1-5 for contemporary churches.

FROM: UNIT 5, EMPHASIZING HOW QUICKLY FALSE DOCTRINE EMERGED DESPITE APOSTOLIC PRESENCE

3. How to 'Un-Christ' Jesus: The Danger of Adding to the Gospel

Using Peter's defense and Thomas Wilcox's piercing phrase, this article examines how requiring anything beyond faith in Jesus for salvation doesn't just distort the gospel — it insults Christ by demeaning the worth of his sacrifice and 'un-Christ's' him as Redeemer.

FROM: UNIT 15, WHERE GAMACHE UNPACKS HOW ADDING TO CHRIST'S WORK OPPOSES GOD AND INSULTS CHRIST

4. Why We Should Have Empathy for the Judaizers

Before we dismiss the first-century legalists, consider their perspective: 1,800 years of covenant history said circumcision mattered. This article traces how understandable theological errors emerge and warns against modern versions of Pharisaical requirement-adding.

FROM: UNITS 8-9, CREATING EMPATHY FOR THE JUDAIZERS AND APPLYING IT TO CONTEMPORARY CHRISTIAN CULTURE

5. When Church Conflict Requires Wider Partnership

The Antioch church recognized that the gospel crisis couldn't be solved locally — it required the involvement of the broader church. This article explores what Acts 15 teaches about when and how to escalate theological disputes beyond the local congregation.

FROM: UNIT 12, HIGHLIGHTING THE OFFICIAL APPOINTMENT AND THE SACRIFICE PAUL AND BARNABAS MADE TO DEFEND THE GOSPEL CORPORATELY

6. God Makes No Distinction: Peter's Radical Claim at the Jerusalem Council

Peter's testimony that God 'made no distinction' between Jew and Gentile, cleansing hearts by faith alone, was revolutionary. This article unpacks the theological weight of verse 9 and its implications for both salvation and the nature of the church.

FROM: UNIT 14, FOCUSING ON PETER'S DEFENSE AND THE CLAIM THAT GOD MAKES NO DISTINCTION

7. The Gentile Mission Was Not Plan B

James's appeal to Amos 9 proves that including the nations wasn't God's afterthought when Israel rejected the Messiah — it was the plan all along. This article traces the Old Testament foundations for the multi-ethnic church and the fulfillment of prophetic hope.

FROM: UNIT 18, WHERE JAMES BRINGS SCRIPTURE TO BEAR SHOWING THAT GENTILE INCLUSION WAS PROPHESED

8. The Difference Between Gospel Requirements and Pastoral Wisdom

The four 'requirements' in Acts 15:20 confuse many readers — are they conditions for salvation or not? This article clarifies that they're pastoral wisdom for multicultural unity, showing how truth cannot be compromised but can be applied in love for the sake of fellowship.

FROM: UNIT 21, DISTINGUISHING BETWEEN SALVATION REQUIREMENTS AND UNITY-PRESERVING PASTORAL COUNSEL

9. Jesus Is Enough: The Only Application of Acts 15

After all the theological debate and careful exegesis, there's only one thing to do with the Jerusalem Council's decision: rejoice that Christ's righteousness is sufficient for salvation. This article explores what it means to simply revel in the all-sufficiency of Jesus.

FROM: UNIT 26, THE CELEBRATORY APPLICATION INVITING BELIEVERS TO REJOICE IN CHRIST'S SUFFICIENCY

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

What was the specific controversy that forced the Jerusalem Council to convene, and why did the false teachers believe their requirement was necessary for salvation?

↳ How might their insistence on circumcision and the law have sounded reasonable to Jewish believers at the time?

ACTS 15:1-5

Peter, Paul, and Barnabas all testified that God makes no distinction between Jews and Gentiles in salvation. What does this reveal about how the gospel fundamentally reshapes our understanding of who belongs to God's people?

↳ How might this have challenged the assumptions of Jewish believers in ways similar to how the gospel challenges our own assumptions today?

ACTS 15:7-9

According to the sermon and the council's decision, what happens theologically when we add anything—even good things like obedience to the law—to faith in Christ as a requirement for salvation?

↳ Can you think of ways this same error shows up in our own thinking about what God requires from us?

ACTS 15:10-11

James quoted Amos 9 to show that God's plan all along was to include Gentiles in His people through faith alone. What does this reveal about the continuity of God's purposes from the Old Testament through the gospel?

↳ How does knowing that salvation by grace alone was always God's plan affect the way you think about your own acceptance with Him?

ACTS 15:13-18

The sermon emphasizes that the application of this passage is simply to rejoice that Jesus is enough. What makes it difficult for us to rest in the sufficiency of Christ's finished work, and what tends to tempt us to add our own effort or obedience as part of our standing before God?

↳ Where do you find yourself most inclined to believe that Christ plus something else is what God requires?

How should the gospel truth that Christ was 'pierced, bloodied, and made unclean' on our behalf reshape the way we approach worship together this week, particularly as we gather around the table for communion?

↳ What would it look like for you to respond with genuine gratitude rather than mere obligation?

Daily Readings

This week we walk through the Jerusalem Council's defense of the gospel—from the peril of doctrinal error, through the apostolic testimony that faith alone saves, to the joyful proclamation that Jesus is enough.

Monday [Acts 2](#)

The Spirit's outpouring at Pentecost established the church's foundation: the proclamation that Jesus alone is Lord and Savior (Acts 2:36). Acts 15 defends this same gospel against those who would add circumcision and the law—a seemingly small addition that would have fractured the church and robbed believers of the assurance that Christ's work is complete. We see how doctrine matters most when the stakes are highest.

Tuesday [Acts 13-14](#)

Paul and Barnabas's missionary journeys (Acts 13-14) brought Gentiles into faith in Christ without the law—yet false teachers demanded circumcision anyway. This confrontation forced the church to answer: Does ethnicity, ritual, or obedience to Moses' law define God's people, or does faith in Christ alone? The council's answer clarified that the church is not a reformed Judaism but a new covenant people, united not by bloodline or legal observance but by grace.

Wednesday [1 Corinthians 15:7](#)

Paul lists James as a witness to the risen Christ, establishing his authority in the Jerusalem Council (1 Corinthians 15:7). James's own testimony upheld the council's decision: salvation comes through faith in Christ, not through the works of the law. We see in the apostolic witness across cultures and backgrounds the same conviction—that the risen Jesus, not human achievement or ancestry, is the foundation of our belonging to God.

Thursday [Amos 9](#)

James quoted Amos 9 to show that God's prophetic word always intended the inclusion of the Gentiles in His covenant people—not as subordinates keeping the law, but as coequal heirs of the promise. When the false teachers demanded circumcision, they contradicted God's own revealed purpose and treated Christ's finished work as insufficient. Every attempt to add human works to the gospel denies the sufficiency of what Jesus accomplished on the cross.

Friday [Acts 16](#)

Acts 16 shows the gospel freed from the burden of the law spreading freely to Asia and Europe, with Paul baptizing believers into Christ alone without any demand for circumcision or legal observance. The joy that fills Acts 16—the jailer's household saved, the slave girl liberated, believers rejoicing—flows directly from the Jerusalem Council's affirmation that faith in Christ is all God requires. We, too, are invited into this freedom: to rest in his finished work and to proclaim the same liberating truth to all nations.

Memory Verse

But we believe that we will be saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they will.
— **Acts 15:11**

This verse captures the sermon's central theological claim — that salvation comes through grace alone in Christ alone, with no distinction between Jew and Gentile and nothing added to faith in Jesus. It is Peter's decisive statement that anchors the Jerusalem Council's resolution and the entire gospel message.

Family Conversation

Is Jesus Enough?

If someone told you that you had to do three extra things before Jesus would save you — like be really good, or follow a special rule, or do a big work — how would that make you feel about Jesus? What does it tell you about him if his work on the cross is enough all by itself?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+ — YOUNGER KIDS CAN LISTEN AND SHARE SIMPLE ANSWERS; SCHOOL-AGE AND TEENS WILL ENGAGE WITH THE DEEPER QUESTION ABOUT WHAT 'ENOUGH' MEANS

For parents: Rick preached today about a big argument in the early church — some people said you had to follow extra rules to be saved, but Peter and Paul said Jesus alone is enough. This prompt invites your family to talk about what it means that nothing needs to be added to what Jesus did for us.

For Couples

Jesus Is Enough

What part of the sermon most stirred your heart about the sufficiency of Christ — and what made it personal rather than abstract for you?

Where do we as a couple tend to add requirements to grace — expecting perfection from each other, performance from our children, or conditions to our forgiveness — rather than resting in Christ's finished work?

What is one specific way you need to hear anew this week that Jesus is enough, and how can I pray that truth into your heart?

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